

third party firewall for added protection. There are several third party firewalls available out there. Some of the best free ones include Online Armor, Comodo and Zone Alarm. All of these are easy to configure and pretty much single click in operation. You can customise and tinker with the settings, but they're designed to be 'install and forget' type of products.

However, the fact remains that a Hardware firewall – one that is built into your router – offers the best form of protection. In fact a few research papers on securityfocus.com have even gone on to expose ways in which software firewalls can be made vulnerable and even bypassed by malware. In this regard, the report goes on to say software firewalls are akin to being made of straw. So, as with antivirus programs, the question arises – should you then have a firewall at all? The answer is yes. Especially if you have a portable PC (notebook) which will definitely be used outside of the protection offered by your router. Also if you are one to install applications like keygens or cracks, then comodo for example allows you to define an application that you most definitely don't want connecting to the net. Comodo seems to be the preferred choice amongst the available free firewalls. If you zero in on Comodo, use the proactive security mode for aggressive protection, alternatively you can use the firewall only setting.

Install anti-spyware

Spyware as we all know is a program that is installed on a PC without the users consent or knowledge and is intended at collecting personal / sensitive information about a user or the computer. An anti spyware is a program that blocks malicious programs from fulfilling their motive. Telltale signs that a computer is infected by spyware include a flood of popups, browsers opening web sites you didn't specify, appearance of bookmarks or new toolbars, etc. The threat of spyware is so great that the US Federal Trade Commission has defined guidelines to deal with the problem. Among the guidelines is the obvious mechanism of installing anti-spyware. There are several anti-spyware suits available. The best among the free ones are Spyware Blaster, Lavasoft's Ad-Aware SE Personal Edition and Spybot Search & Destroy. S&D has functions such as SDHelper and TeaTimer that are quite useful. The paid software offer higher detection rates. There is also the option of installing Windows Defender which is included with all versions of Windows Vista and is available to download free for genuine copies of Windows XP SP2 or later. Many people use anti-spyware in combination so as to add multiple layers of security. But should a conflict occur, it is recommended to use only one solution at a time.

Run rootkit checker

A rootkit is a method by which a piece of malware hides itself from antimalware utilities such as antivirus and antispysware programs. There are various kinds of rootkits such as persistent, user-mode and kernel rootkits that hide themselves from process lists and even registry entries. RootkitRevealer from Sysinternals is a powerful detection tool that successfully detects many persistent rootkits including AFX, Vanquish and HackerDefender. The way it works its that it shows discrepancies in registry hive entries and the files accessed by the Windows API. To scan a system, launch Rootkit Revealer on the system and press the Scan button. RootkitRevealer scans the system reporting its actions in a status area at the bottom of its window and noting discrepancies in the output list. Once a rootkit is revealed it's best to format the system or follow removal procedures for specific rootkits that can be found on the Sysinternals forums. Since this is a post infection measure, it's a firefighting technique. However, since this is an advanced level configuration, proceed only if you're sure of what you're doing.

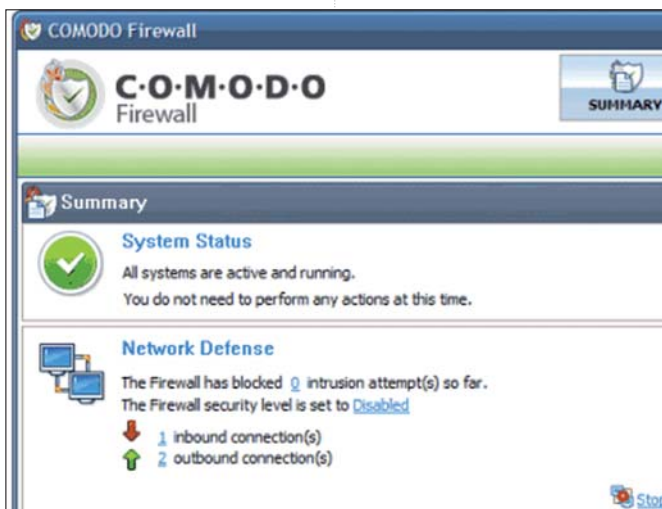
Follow safe computing and security best practices

Any old hand in the field of security will tell you that the best prevention measures

come from the users side. If you are a careful user you can prevent most malware from entering your system. More than antivirus software, your common sense should be the first line of defence against malware. Don't get what we mean? It's quite simple, if you follow these best practices norms:

Keep software up to date

Having up-to-date software means that the latest vulnerabilities that the developers have detected have been patched up. This makes software more stable and less susceptible to attacks. You should make sure that popular products such as Opera, Firefox, Flash plugins and media players are definitely updated, since malware coders are constantly on the lookout for exploiting them. Most applications have auto updates but if for some reason they don't work or have been disabled then you would have to check manually for each and every application installed on your system. A better way to check version status is with Secunia OSI – Online Software Inspector (http://secunia.com/vulnerability_scanning/online/). It will scan your system and give you details of problem areas and suggestions about which applications need to be updated. There is also the Personal Software Inspector (PSI) application which is



Comodo firewall



Secunia PSI at work